

Best Diet for Rheumatoid Arthritis (UK): Evidence-Based Nutrit

Evidence-based dietary guide for rheumatoid arthritis in the UK. Discover the best anti-inflammatory foods, meal plans, foods to avoid and supplements for RA management.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-02-07 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Living with rheumatoid arthritis (RA) means managing a chronic autoimmune condition where the immune system attacks the joints. While medication is the cornerstone of RA treatment, growing evidence confirms that diet plays an important complementary role in managing inflammation, supporting immune health and improving overall well-being. This guide covers the best evidence-based dietary strategies for RA, tailored to foods available in the UK.

Why Diet Matters in Rheumatoid Arthritis

RA is driven by immune system dysfunction and chronic inflammation. Certain dietary patterns can modulate the immune response and inflammatory pathways. Research from the University of Manchester and the British Society for Rheumatology shows that the **Mediterranean diet** reduces inflammatory markers (CRP, ESR) that drive RA, dietary omega-3 fatty acids inhibit the same inflammatory pathways targeted by biologic drugs, gut microbiome health — strongly influenced by diet — plays a role in autoimmune conditions, and maintaining a healthy weight reduces joint stress and inflammatory adipokine production.

The Mediterranean Diet for RA



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The Mediterranean diet is the most studied and recommended dietary pattern for RA management. A landmark trial published in *Annals of the Rheumatic Diseases* found that RA patients following a Mediterranean diet for 12 weeks experienced significant reductions in disease activity, pain and inflammatory markers compared to a control group.

Daily Staples

- Extra-virgin olive oil — Use as your primary cooking and salad oil. Contains oleocanthal, which has anti-inflammatory effects comparable to low-dose ibuprofen. Choose cold-pressed, extra-virgin varieties
- Vegetables — Aim for 5–7 portions daily. Prioritise green leafy vegetables (spinach, kale, broccoli), colourful peppers, tomatoes, sweet potatoes and beetroot

- Fruits — 2–3 portions daily. Berries (blueberries, strawberries, cherries) are particularly rich in anti-inflammatory anthocyanins
- Whole grains — Oats, brown rice, quinoa, wholemeal bread. Provide fibre that supports beneficial gut bacteria
- Legumes — Lentils, chickpeas, beans. Excellent plant protein with anti-inflammatory properties
- Nuts and seeds — Walnuts (omega-3s), almonds, flaxseeds, chia seeds. A small handful daily

Weekly Priorities

- Oily fish 2–3 times per week — Salmon, mackerel, sardines, herring. The omega-3 fatty acids EPA and DHA are the most potent dietary anti-inflammatories available
 - Poultry — Chicken and turkey as lean protein sources
 - Eggs — Rich in protein, vitamin D and selenium
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Foods to Limit or Avoid

Certain foods can promote inflammation and may trigger RA flares in some individuals:

- Processed and ultra-processed foods — Ready meals, crisps, biscuits. High in refined fats, sugars and additives that promote inflammation
- Added sugars — Fizzy drinks, sweets, cakes. Sugar triggers the release of inflammatory cytokines
- Red and processed meats — Bacon, sausages, burgers. High in saturated fat and arachidonic acid (a pro-inflammatory fatty acid)
- Refined carbohydrates — White bread, white pasta, white rice. Cause rapid blood sugar spikes that promote inflammation
- Alcohol — Particularly important if taking methotrexate, as both are processed by the liver. Discuss safe limits with your rheumatologist. Many RA specialists recommend complete avoidance on methotrexate

- Excess salt — May promote inflammation and is linked to increased RA disease activity in some studies

Individual Food Triggers

Some RA patients report specific food triggers, though evidence is largely anecdotal. Commonly reported triggers include gluten (wheat, barley, rye), dairy products (milk, cheese, yoghurt), nightshade vegetables (tomatoes, peppers, aubergines, potatoes), and corn and soy products. If you suspect a food trigger, try an elimination approach under a dietitian's guidance — remove the suspect food for 4–6 weeks, then reintroduce it while monitoring symptoms. Do not eliminate multiple food groups without professional advice, as this risks nutritional deficiencies.

Key Nutrients for RA



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Omega-3 Fatty Acids

The strongest evidence for dietary RA management. A meta-analysis of 20 randomised controlled trials found that omega-3 supplementation significantly reduced joint pain, morning stiffness and NSAID use. Target 2–3g combined EPA+DHA daily from fish and/or supplements.

Vitamin D

Vitamin D deficiency is common in RA patients and associated with higher disease activity. The UK has limited sunlight during winter months, making supplementation important. NICE recommends all UK adults consider a 10 mcg (400 IU) daily supplement from October to March. RA patients may benefit from higher doses — discuss with your rheumatologist. Blood levels should ideally be above 50 nmol/L.

Antioxidants

Vitamins C and E, selenium and carotenoids help combat oxidative stress that damages joint tissues. Eat a wide variety of colourful fruits and vegetables — the "eat a rainbow" approach ensures broad antioxidant coverage.

Fibre and Gut Health

Emerging research links gut microbiome composition to RA activity. A diverse gut microbiome, supported by high-fibre diets, may help modulate immune function. Include prebiotic foods (garlic, onions, leeks, asparagus, bananas) and fermented foods (yoghurt, kefir, sauerkraut, kimchi) to support beneficial gut bacteria.

Sample RA-Friendly Meal Plan

- Breakfast — Overnight oats with ground flaxseed, mixed berries, a handful of walnuts and a drizzle of honey
- Mid-morning snack — Green smoothie (spinach, banana, ginger, turmeric, almond milk)
- Lunch — Grilled mackerel fillet with roasted Mediterranean vegetables, mixed leaf salad and olive oil dressing
- Afternoon snack — Apple slices with almond butter

- Dinner — Chickpea and sweet potato curry with turmeric, ginger and coconut milk, served with brown rice
 - Evening — Chamomile or ginger tea
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Practical Tips for the UK



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- Frozen berries, vegetables and fish fillets are nutritious and often cheaper than fresh
- Tinned fish (sardines, mackerel) provides affordable omega-3s
- Batch cooking on good days means healthy meals are available during flare-ups
- Ask your GP about NHS dietitian referral for personalised RA dietary advice
- Check food labels using the UK traffic-light system to avoid hidden sugars and saturated fats

Diet is a powerful tool in your RA management toolkit. While it cannot replace medication, the right eating pattern can reduce inflammation, improve symptoms and support your overall health. Our virtual assistant can help you plan anti-inflammatory meals tailored to your preferences.

This article is for general information only. Consult your rheumatologist or a registered dietitian before making significant dietary changes, especially if you take medications like methotrexate.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about best diet for rheumatoid arthritis uk: evidence-based nutrit?

Short answer: The Mediterranean diet is recommended for managing Rheumatoid Arthritis (RA) and involves daily staples like extra-virgin olive oil, 5–7 portions of vegetables, 2–3 portions of fruit, whole grains, legumes, and nuts and seeds. Weekly priorities include oily fish 2–3 times and poultry and eggs. Foods to limit or avoid include processed items, added sugars, red meat, refined carbohydrates, and potentially alcohol and excess salt.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk